

It was a typical June morning in Bengaluru. The garden city showed off its best weather—temperature at a cool 23-25 degrees, marginally overcast sky, slight drizzle at times, the sun peeking through now and then to spread warmth and cheer.

Traffic, though, was quite the opposite. Crowded. Exasperating. Especially on NH75 near Nagasandra. Traffic had come to a standstill. But the reason was not only rush hour. If you looked closely, you could see cars queued up to enter a new, elegant, blue building bearing the legend “IKEA”. Once your car got in and got parked, you had to endure another serpentine queue of smiling, curious folks. The store opened at 10 am, but chances are you spent three hours in various queues before you finally got inside the building.

Not that this dampened the enthusiasm of Bengaluru residents, who thronged the maze of aisles and rows of the 460,000-sq. ft store in the thousands to take a peek at IKEA’s signature furniture, Japanese kitchen knives and other snazzy products. A grinning Ram Babu and his family were caught up in the frenzy. Babu, a bureaucrat and father of three teenagers, was checking out the vast range of affordable cutlery on his wife’s invitation, but had great difficulty managing an uncompromising crowd that conveniently ignored his elbow jabs, even as his daughter Sheetal

lost herself in search of decorative plants. The 1,000-seater restaurant on the second floor of the Blue Box—the nickname of a standalone IKEA large-format store—could be accessed after enduring a wait of an hour as Swedish meatballs and mango pastries flew off the shelves. But the thousands of visitors, the Babus included, were in no mood to check out anytime soon.

As the crowds surged around her, the tiny, frail-looking Susanne Pulverer was caught in a heavy stream of downward-moving visitors on a broad staircase. Decked up in IKEA’s signature yellow top and blue skirt, the Swedish national looked delighted, gauging the mood of her customers. (Sweden, incidentally, regularly ranks among the 10 happiest countries in the world.) Despite the crowds and the visible enthusiasm of consumers towards the brand, the 62-year-old Pulverer, CEO and Chief Sustainability Officer of IKEA India, has a big task ahead.

Nobody needs to tell her that. Pulverer knows India well, having spent two stints here, the first as a sourcing manager for the country starting 2007. The soft-spoken

IKEA veteran also gathered market experience from her stint as Local Community Leader and was present during IKEA’s first store launch in Hyderabad in mid-2018. No surprise, then, that in January 2022, the global executives in the Netherlands put their bet on Pulverer for their India gambit to succeed. “It’s a big, big country and we have just started to enter. There is so much to do,” says Pulverer. She adds that India is a “very important growth market for IKEA”, and while it has five stores here, “this is just the beginning”.

For the \$42-billion Swedish-founded, Dutch-headquartered home furnishings giant, cracking the India market is important. IKEA clinched the title of the largest furniture retailer in the world in 2008. Yet, despite its presence in 64 countries across five continents, including the oil economies of the UAE, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia, and emerging economies like China, Russia and India, IKEA continues to depend heavily on the stagnating economies of Western Europe and North America. Nearly 73 per cent of its stores are located in these two regions, with Europe alone housing 277 Blue Boxes, of a total 472 worldwide. In comparison, the market in India is growing faster and with per capita consumption of furniture remaining low, opportunity beckons.

However, India is not an easy market to crack, as several multinational companies have found to their dismay. The character of the Indian consumer is hard to understand and serve. There’s competition lurking everywhere. In the case of IKEA, competition would range from large organised players like Godrej Interio to new-age upstarts like Pepperfry to the thousands of unorganised players in the ‘furniture markets’